Westbrook City Council

~ Committee of the Whole ~

Date: Monday, July 20, 2026
Time: 6:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1211506780
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_07202026-1018

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *This was a discussion-only Committee of the Whole session with no formal Council votes; summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Unofficial summary. *This is produced by Westbrook Currents, an independent site — not the City of Westbrook — and may contain mistakes. For the official record, see the City's approved minutes and the meeting video.*

Review Methodology: Boards, Commissions & Committees Ordinance Overhaul

City Administrator Angela Holmes's Overview [1:22]

Discussion Summary

This was the first of at least three planned Committee of the Whole sessions reviewing a comprehensive overhaul of the Code of Ordinances governing the City's twelve boards, commissions, and committees (BCCs). Holmes explained staff have not conducted a comprehensive review of all BCC ordinance language in recent memory, and some sections no longer reflect current operations.

Each board is evaluated against five questions: is its purpose clear and non-conflicting; is its membership appropriately sized and qualified; are its duties clear and non-duplicative of staff/department functions; is its scope of authority consistent with state law and the City Charter; and a set of standardized clerical corrections — capping term lengths at three years (unless state law requires otherwise), removing ward-specific representation requirements, eliminating gendered language, standardizing term-end dates to June 30, and correcting each body's title to match whether it functions as a board (quasi-judicial/regulatory), commission (policy development), or committee (advisory/working group).

Holmes also noted a parallel effort, led by City Clerk Ledoux and City Solicitor Ferrante, to standardize agenda, minutes, and public-notice practices and to better publicize open BCC vacancies. Two further review sessions are planned (September 14 for five additional boards, and September 21 reserved for final discussion), with Council adoption anticipated around October 5.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Board of Assessment Review

Proposed Changes & Ward Representation Debate [11:19]

Found on page 4 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

This seven-member board (five ward seats, two at-large) currently has no sitting members. Staff recommend reducing it to five members (state law allows five to seven; most neighboring communities use five), removing the ward-specific seat requirement, adding a duties section and state-statute reference currently missing from the ordinance, and shortening terms from five to three years with staggered expirations ending June 30.

Councilor Chau asked how often the board actually meets; staff explained it convenes only as-needed when a resident formally appeals a property assessment, since staff typically resolve concerns informally first.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken; this item remains open pending further staff work.

Action Items

None.

Point/Counterpoint — ward representation. Councilor Turcotte pushed back on removing the ward-specific seats, recounting being told early in her tenure that Ward 3 struggles to find volunteers because it is "the poorest ward," and arguing geographic and immigrant-community representation shouldn't be abandoned just because seats go unfilled.

> *"I think it's important for every ward to be represented... I'd like some [note] to see what other council members think... if we could document that preference will go to represent other ward members... rather than just whoever is available, whoever has free time to sit on these committees."*

— Councilor Anna Turcotte [18:39]

Staff (Franceschi) responded that removing ward requirements on other bodies (the Planning Board and Zoning Board of Appeals) in the past resolved real staffing problems, where willing volunteers were turned away because no seat was open for their specific ward. Mayor Morse, a former councilor, recalled the City previously removed ward requirements from the Public Safety Commission, ZBA, and Planning Board for the same reason, while affirming geographic balance can still be weighed informally when recommending appointees. Turcotte asked whether that intent could be codified as a written policy directing future administrations to still weigh ward representation as a factor even without a hard requirement; Mayor Morse suggested a mission statement listing it as a factor and said he would talk to staff about it. No vote was taken.

Board of Trustees of Woodlawn Cemetery — Proposed Elimination

Staff Recommends Eliminating the Board [26:49]

Found on page 7 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

This three-member board also has no sitting members. Staff's recommendation goes beyond clerical cleanup: eliminate the board entirely, finding its duties duplicate functions already performed by the Public Services and

Finance Departments, and that its stated scope of authority conflicts with the City Council's, the Mayor's, and various departments' authority over cemetery fee-setting and management. The surrounding ordinance language also references an obsolete “Director of Parks and Cemeteries” position whose duties have since split between the Directors of Public Services and Community Services, which staff are still finalizing language to reflect. Other cleanup includes removing gendered language and renaming “Pauper's Graves” to “Public Graves.”

Councilor Chau voiced a concern he returned to twice: that boards shouldn't be eliminated simply because the City doesn't like them, only because their function is genuinely redundant; he said he was comfortable with this specific elimination on the merits but wanted that principle on the record for future reviews. Staff agreed explicitly with the distinction. Another councilor noted cemeteries are quasi-public spaces that matter deeply to residents and suggested some mechanism for public input should remain even without a dedicated board. President Munro recalled a past trustee's hands-on groundskeeping work with personal fondness, cautioning against dismissing the board's historical contributions, but did not object to the elimination given the duplicated duties and the board's already-vacant status.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken; final elimination language returns to Council later this year.

Action Items

None.

Fair Hearing Authority (General Assistance Appeals)

Renaming to a Board; Avoiding Ordinance/State-Law Conflicts [37:24]

Found on page 14 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

This body (no current members; Councilor Chau's own appointment expired in February) hears appeals from residents denied General Assistance. Staff recommend clarifying membership as up to three qualified individuals (changing “residents” to “individuals,” since relevant expertise matters more than local residency), renaming the body from “Authority” to “Board” to reflect its quasi-judicial function, and updating the staff title “General Assistance Administrator” to “General Assistance Director” to match current practice.

Councilor Chau, drawing on his own experience on the board, described it as a deceptively demanding seat: hearings must be convened within five days of an appeal (a state-law requirement), difficult to schedule among volunteer members, with unscheduled cases sometimes referred to Portland's hearing authority instead. He cautioned against over-specifying local ordinance language beyond state law — particularly a draft section implying the City would write its own rules and regulations for General Assistance administration. Harrison Deah, Director of General Assistance & Social Services, explained the City adopts the Maine Municipal Association's model ordinance each year, so it doesn't have to draft its own; staff agreed to look at referencing state law by citation rather than restating it. Councilor Faulkingham asked what “qualified” means in practice; staff clarified it refers to experience with due-process hearings, General Assistance law, or similar proceedings.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Library Advisory Committee

Minor Cleanup Only [49:04]

Found on page 18 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

The lightest-touch item of the evening: this five-member body (two current members, three vacancies) was substantially rewritten roughly four years ago, when it was renamed from the “Library Board of Trustees” and clarified as purely advisory, distinct from the separate Walker Memorial Board of Regents established under the will of Joseph Walker. Staff found its purpose, membership size, duties, and scope of authority all already appropriate, proposing only minor cleanup: clarifying that “The Library” refers to the Walker Memorial Library as a City department, relocating a confusingly placed reference to the Will of Walker to a more appropriate section, and standard staggering/numbering fixes.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Closing

Public Comment, Vacancy Applications & Adjournment [54:38]

Discussion Summary

No public comment was offered. The Committee was reminded of the two remaining review sessions: September 14 (Recreation & Conservation Commission, Planning Board, Village Review Overlay Zone Committee, Zoning Board of Appeals, and Public Safety Commission) and September 21 (reserved for final discussion). City Clerk Ledoux explained residents can apply for any open board seat via the Boards & Committees section of westbrookmaine.gov. The Committee of the Whole adjourned and moved directly into the Special City Council meeting that followed the same night.

Key Decisions

✓ Motion to adjourn approved by voice vote.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was transcribed with AI-assisted speech-to-text and speaker identification. This process cross-checked names and figures against the official packet and the city council roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the presiding officer) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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